

Seizure-Like Episodes

Not every "episode" is a seizure. Several conditions can look very similar, and telling them apart changes the treatment.

Conditions that can look like seizures

- **Vestibular (balance) episodes** — sudden head tilt, rolling, abnormal eye movements
- **Fainting (syncope)** — brief collapse from a heart rhythm or blood pressure problem
- **Metabolic disease** — low blood sugar, electrolyte imbalances
- **Neuromuscular disease** — episodic weakness or collapse
- **Movement disorders** — abnormal movements while fully awake
- **REM sleep behavior disorder** — acting out dreams during sleep
- **Neck pain** — sudden crying, trembling or stiffening
- **Spikes in pressure inside the skull**
- **Cataplexy** — sudden loss of muscle tone, often with excitement
- **Panic or anxiety attacks**
- **Myoclonus** — sudden, brief muscle jerks

How you can help us tell the difference

- **Video the episode** whenever it is safe — this is the single most helpful thing you can do.
- Note whether your pet was **aware and responsive** during the episode.
- Note what happened **before** (sleeping, exercise, excitement, eating) and **after** (confused, tired, or normal right away).
- If you can, check heart rate, breathing and gum color (see our *Checking Vitals at Home* handout).
- Keep a log of the date, time and length of each episode.

Tests that may help

- Neurological and physical exam, blood work
- Heart evaluation if fainting is suspected
- MRI and spinal fluid analysis
- **EEG (electroencephalogram)** — records the brain's electrical activity and is very useful for telling true seizures from seizure-like episodes

If an episode lasts longer than 5 minutes, or your pet does not return to normal afterward, seek emergency care.